

Staff Days — Week 2, Day 9 (Thu Aug 6)

Format note: No Joe — he left after his birthday session. This was a working day: final behavior policy revisions, the intervention tiers underneath it, a Guide Platform data-schema session, and a lunch-and-learn on the new student information system.

Behavior policy — final revisions

0:46–1:20 — Matt Shenker

Legal came back with minimal changes, which Matt read as a good sign. The framing stays the same: this is the first standardized behavior model at this scale, nobody expects it to be right, and it's a living document — track what you'd change and surface it.

What changed

Wonder Lab got real differentiation. Two warnings **per schedule block** before a yellow (LL is two per day), and Wonder Lab is the **only level that gets a warning before a red card**, valid for the day. Reasoning: a 9am conversation about not throwing things is something a four-year-old can hold until 2pm — you shouldn't need six warnings, but you also shouldn't need zero. Where interpretation is genuinely ambiguous at that age, the Wonder Lab team plus leads and head guides decide case by case, and the wisdom gets built back into the model.

Middle school got no change. The request to escalate severity was declined for now. The argument: ask any middle school guide how often last year they saw something below red-card level that they wanted to address and didn't — the answer is constantly. Warnings will now be far more common *and tracked*, and the warning → yellow → red cycle is itself the fix. Watch how it lands before ratcheting.

Boot camp practice for day one. The **first three days of school — Wednesday, Thursday, Friday of Calendar A week 1 — are entirely coaching**. Grace is given, the model is taught, boundary-crossings become coaching conversations rather than warnings and cards. The behavior model is in full effect the Monday of the first full week. **Don't tell students this** — nobody wants it to feel like three days of the purge. Standards still exist; only enforcement is different.

Prohibited items and curse words. The doc now has the most exhaustive curse-word list they could build. Implied substitutes (*fudge*, *shiitake*) aren't listed, because the line always produces an edge case; the working rule is whether it's directed at someone and whether it's in the level space vs. the playground. Escalate ambiguity to your lead.

Weapons are a strike with **one exception: pepper spray or mace** for middle schoolers who walk in cities like San Francisco and New York. It gets turned in to a guide before launch and returned at dismissal.

Violent language. Any threat of violence now escalates immediately to the strike review team, who determine whether it was substantive — that determination is what makes it appealable or not. Language distinguishing minor disrespect from targeted unkindness was also added.

The strike review team is the lead guide, head guide, and DOP. They are the same people as the expulsion review team, but the doc now names them as two distinct functions: they review every strike, and they can escalate any strike for expulsion review.

The example worth remembering

A student does an accurate Trump impression and says "I'm gonna bomb Venezuela." Not directed at the school or any student, not credible. **That's nothing.** Not a red, not a strike. Depending on where and when, it might be a disruptive yellow — but on the playground at recess with a guide walking by, nothing in the model needs to fire.

The broader point Matt wanted landed: **warnings, yellows, reds, and strikes are not your only tools.** Plenty of things kids say and do warrant coaching and don't break a boundary — breaking a promise to a friend, weird startling noises, a muttered "what the F" on the playground. That's guide magic, and most behavioral transformation happens there.

Phones — the room changed the policy live

The doc said smartwatches could be worn but not used for calling or texting, with loss of the privilege if caught. Austin Middle School (whose phone jail is branded the **Phone Spa**) pushed back: it's unmonitorable, especially in bathrooms. The evidence that piled on:

- Kids messaging parents mid-day; Austin L1 heard about it at pickup
- Two Spyglass cases of students messaging home about a **strike before the guide could tell parents** — directly undermining the DOP goal of beating the story home
- Recording capability
- Use during off-campus events with parents present
- NextGen's equity point: if only some kids have watches while everyone else surrenders phones, you create a status dynamic and pressure to get one

NextGen also offered the honest counterargument — treating students as capable of responsible tech use, the same way we hand them AI — and conceded it wasn't strong enough. **Decision: smartwatches are phones.** They go in the phone spa. The doc is being updated.

High school lets students unlock phone privileges. Scaling that down to 8th grade is possible **only once a responsible-use curriculum exists**, which doesn't yet. Santa Barbara is building one.

Tier 1 canon: no phone, tablet, or watch from launch until dismissal without specific guide permission. **Tier 2:** phone jails, Faraday bags, unlock systems during boot camp — that's yours to design, and share what works.

DOPs own communicating this to parents, not guides. A revised **Alpha Global Policies and Procedures Handbook** (formerly the Student Handbook), legal-reviewed and aligned to the behavior policy, goes out with acknowledgment of receipt. Campuses expecting friction should coordinate with their DOP — some are printing it for Meet the Guides night so no parent can say they weren't told.

Students with additional needs

David Cooney, the school counselor, is the resource — both for surfacing information about incoming students with IEPs and for shaping supports when the standard structure isn't working. If you think you're missing information about a student, have your lead reach out.

Tom Bennett's position, which Alpha adopted: these students **should be held to the same standard**. Schools that quietly lower the bar are doing them a disservice, because the message the kid receives is that they can't meet it. **The accommodation belongs in the 95%, not the 5%.**

The intervention tiers

1:20–2:03

Pirate Ship

Bryan Gordon built it at Alpha Middle School about four years ago, for what he called **active detractors** — students who weren't just missing community standards themselves but pulling others away from them. A separate intensive cohort with stricter rules than the general community, their own teamwork and community-standards workshops, and a **four-week window** to demonstrate change. Three slips in a week resets you to week one. Austin Way got out in four weeks; others took sixteen.

The goal isn't changing the behavior, it's changing the habits around it — which is why it's four weeks and not four days.

New trigger this year: any student who doesn't graduate boot camp at the end of Session 1's eight weeks. Think of it as core life skill hole-filling, the exact parallel to academic hole-filling. It can run for one student or a cohort, and Steph committed to **staffing a dedicated guide** for a cohort where there's critical mass: *"I'd rather give a kid a one-on-one guide and do what we can to keep them in our system before just saying, please exit Alpha."*

Open question flagged and not yet answered: kindergarteners who simply need more time. A decision will come before week 4–5 of Session 1 so nothing is a surprise.

Name origin: Rocket Ship was the fully-unlocked kids. Someone proposed Pirate Ship for the other group and Joe got obsessed. The first cohort made their own flag and wore it with pride. The middle school version is called Black Pearl.

Behavior support plans

The step below Pirate Ship — additional structure, a specific motivational model, and explicit goals shared with the parent and student. Triggered at end-of-session **feathers and fixes** for every level, when you're going kid by kid and asking who needs more. **For LL specifically, two red cards in a session** triggers a review for whether one is needed.

Strike appeals — the Master Appeal Template

Last year every appeal was built one-off, on a deadline, while also communicating home. Now there's a standardized template for pre-K–8. **Three components:**

1. **Uphold baseline expectations** — close your rings daily, no further yellows, reds, or strikes.
2. **Master a module** teaching the skill they broke — honesty, doing your own work, taking care of things. Scenarios go through a prebuilt **AI grader**; ten days, unlimited attempts, mastery required. If they can't master it, that's a signal to teach it better. Then they produce a short doc or video teaching it to someone else, which becomes a resource for other kids.
3. **A repair action** that actually rectifies what they did.

13 modules exist — 6 for appealable strikes, 7 for non-appealable. They're not built per level; older kids are close to plug-and-play, and littles need adaptation. Each insert pulls the specific "**I can**" **statements** from the behavior curriculum the student clearly hasn't mastered, which anchors the conversation with both the kid and the parent.

Structure and content are Tier 1. Delivery and language are Tier 2 and 3.

Repair plans — non-appealable strikes

A non-appealable strike means the student **goes home that day and stays home the rest of the day**. Their re-entry ticket has two parts: a written note taking ownership (replacing the town hall ownership option), and completing the module at home before returning. The repair plan itself must be finished within one week of returning. If they show up not having mastered the module, they stay at school working on it rather than being sent home again.

Guide Platform — data schema and the health score

2:05–3:15

Steph and Alec mapped every workflow guides run and **attached each one to a pillar**, so the system can roll up an aggregate health score per campus. The reasoning is Joe's: *you can never go to Denver, so how do you know if Denver is delivering?*

Rostering errors are not Alec's fault — he's waiting on the new CIS to provide unique student IDs so every data point can attach to a kid.

What gets captured: meetings (1:1 limitless meetings, limitless lunches — five a year — plus town hall, launch, and closing via audio recording with AI processing); behavior inputs including support plans, appeals, and Pirate Ship; workshops fed in through Ben's Guide's Guide Builder, which populates baseline, checkpoint 1, checkpoint 2, and alpha test; **3Cs self-reports**, reframed as *intermittent feathers* — every other week you ask whether you're delivering, and now the system closes the loop on whether your fix worked; and **individualized motivational models**, which now get logged with a goal and a duration so efficacy is trackable rather than invented and forgotten.

Cadence flip-flops: baseline week 2, 3Cs week 3, checkpoint 1, 3Cs, and so on.

Custom triggers. Rather than filing a request with Super Builders, guides can ask Alec directly for signals TimeBack doesn't surface — flag a kid who hasn't taken a test in X days — and the threshold stays tunable if it turns out to be noisy.

Core life skills measurement. Each session, **peer 360 questions** scaled by level, aligned with the parent-facing questions and DESA and the core life skills, plus the guide's version on the accountability report. Three sources triangulated into something like a MAP score for life skills, with growth measurable over time. Steph's note: it makes for a much better parent conversation than opinion — *you came in thinking your kid was off the charts on grit; here's what their peers and their guide observed.*

Accountability reports should be dramatically lighter this year because the platform pulls from what you enter daily. The lesson from summer, credited to Sean McKenna: take lots of notes daily and the report writes itself.

Admissions shadow days are being standardized — the life skills and boot camp standards are now defined well enough to build the rubric one level underneath them, plus dashboard visibility so campuses get calibrated against each other. This is the direct answer to yesterday's problem of some campuses saying yes to everyone and others saying no to half.

New input from parents: DOPs will collect each family's stack-rank of which pillars they care about most at the start of the year, reflected in the student profile.

The Alpha economy is changing

- **Alphas are now only for XP/academics and job responsibilities.** No alphas tied to behavior. No "everyone on your dot in 30 seconds and you all get 5 alphas." Behavior belongs to the behavior policy, coaching, and core life skills — don't conflate the systems. Other motivational levers stay available as Tier 3 guide magic.
 - Daily alpha earning is being **standardized across campuses** so a kid in San Francisco and a kid in Miami earn the same on a given Monday.
 - **No more physical alphas at L1 and above.** TimeBack and Guide Platform are the source of truth. LL and Wonder Lab keep physical coins, but as a *mirror* of the balance, not additional currency. Austin L1 pushed back that the physical tokens were developmentally valuable; the answer was that running both systems at once doesn't scale and L1 needs to start investing and saving. Explicitly open to revisiting after a couple of sessions.
 - **TimeBack owns the checking, savings, and investment accounts; Guide Platform mirrors them** and adds bonuses, fines, and jobs. It's a mirror, not a second bank — awarding in Guide Platform writes to TimeBack via API.
 - **Emporium** is moving in: a physical card with a QR code, an iPad app holding each school's inventory, scan to purchase, automatic deduction and an emailed receipt. Pricing algorithm: round up to the nearest 5, then multiply by 4. Kids accrue alphas during boot camp but **the Emporium doesn't unlock until boot camp is complete.**
 - **Jobs** pay 1–2 alphas a day depending on the job. Job *types* are consistent (town hall mayor, cleanup crew) but the list is a town hall decision, not a standardized menu. Unresolved debate: several people argued that if checks aren't paid, jobs shouldn't be either; Carson's counter is that check charts already carry inherent motivation (leveling up, staying with your friends) and jobs don't yet.
 - Big org-wide XP pushes around holidays would be decided board-wide, not through a per-guide bonus button.
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Lunch and Learn — the new CIS

3:15–4:06 — Kendra Swalls, registrar

The headline for guides is **attendance is simpler than you think**. As an independent school Alpha has no state reporting requirement, so **excused vs. unexcused and doctor's notes are unnecessary** — that's a public-school funding mechanism. An absence is an absence. What does matter is that **Cognia accreditation requires an attendance policy and records**, and that patterns (chronic lateness, consistently leaving before afternoon workshops) are useful data in parent conversations about academic performance.

Two requests made and accepted on the spot: a **"mark all present"** bulk action so you only edit the exceptions, and an **off-site present** status for students traveling for experiences or

competitions — so they don't count as absent but are still accounted for in a building emergency.

Campus coordinators will likely own tardy and early-pickup updates since they're at the front desk, but guides can update too. **Guide assignments live in Guide Platform, not the CIS.**

A sandbox account is being sent out to play in without consequence, with Loom videos and SOPs to follow. Questions go to registrar@alpha.school or the registrar support Slack channel.